In the name of Him who gave us sovereignty,
Who gave us a wise heart and a strong arm
Who guided us in equity and justice
Who put away from our heart aught but equity:
His praise is beyond the range of our thoughts
Exalted be his Majesty—Allahu Akbar!

The Mazhar of 1579 caused considerable disquiet, both in its own time and in the many interpretations attributed to it over the centuries. Apart from Shaikh Mubarak, it is likely that most of the other ulema signed the document under duress, submitting to pressure from the court. When the ulema of Delhi, the next most important city after the capital, were asked to sign the mazhar, Shaikh Jamaluddin refused, saying ‘why should we faqirs and people living in seclusion be troubled?’ referring to the greater austerity of the Delhi shaikhs and their careful distance from the glamour and lure of the court. Rumours began to spread that the imperial qazis had been forced, against their better judgement, to sign the document. The reading of the khutba was viewed with even more unease. The phrase ‘Allahu Akbar’* was deliberately ambiguous yet almost insouciantly provocative. Even Babur and Humayun had had the traditional khutba recited, nominally giving reverence to the Ottoman Sultan. Akbar now deliberately distanced himself from acknowledging the OttomanSultan as overlord of all Islamic kingdoms and instead claimed for himself the role of king of the orthodox Muslims of Hindustan and for the Mughal Empire an equally righteous claim to rule in the land.

In response to these upheavals, there was a fusillade of caustic and sharp one-liners from critical courtiers and observers. Mullah Sheri, a courtier ‘renowned for his devastating one-liners as much as for his Islamic orthodoxy,’ according to historian Harbans Mukhia, said ‘this year His Majesty has laid claim to being the Prophet, next year, if God wills, he will become God himself ’. Other courtiers, loath to attack the Padshah, laid the blame on Shaikh Mubarak’s sons, Abu’l Fazl and Faizi. The poet Urfi of Shiraz made an allusion to this scandalous influence when he wrote, ‘O Prophet, protect the Joseph of my soul (i.e. my soul) from the harm of the brothers; for they are ungenerous and envious, and deceive me like evil spirits and lead me wolf-like to the well (of unbelief )’. Akbar was particularly piqued when any reference was made to the disapproval of Ottoman sensibilities. When Qutbuddin Khan and Shahbaz Khan objected